

MAHASHIVRATRI



MAHASHIVRATRI, MEANING "THE GREAT NIGHT OF SHIVA, IT IS OBSERVED ON THE 14TH NIGHT OF THE WANING MOON IN THE MONTH OF PHALGUNA OR MAGHA (FEBRUARY-MARCH). "

THIS NIGHT IS DEDICATED TO LORD SHIVA, THE SUPREME CONSCIOUSNESS, AND IS ASSOCIATED WITH DEEP SPIRITUAL SIGNIFICANCE, YOGIC WISDOM, AND COSMIC TRANSFORMATION.

ACCORDING TO THE VEDAS AND AGAMAS, MAHASHIVRATRI IS THE NIGHT WHEN LORD SHIVA PERFORMS THE ANANDA TANDAVA (DANCE OF BLISS), SYMBOLIZING THE RHYTHMIC CYCLE OF CREATION, PRESERVATION, AND DESTRUCTION.

DEVI PARVATI, AFTER YEARS OF PENANCE, ATTAINED LORD SHIVA AS HER CONSORT, REPRESENTING THE FUSION OF PURUSHA (PURE CONSCIOUSNESS) AND PRAKRITI (DIVINE ENERGY)—THE FOUNDATION OF ALL CREATION ON THIS DAY.

ACCORDING TO THE BHAGAVATA PURANA AND VISHNU PURANA, DURING THE CHURNING OF THE COSMIC OCEAN, THE DEADLY POISON HALAHALA EMERGED. TO SAVE THE UNIVERSE, LORD SHIVA DRANK IT, HOLDING IT IN HIS THROAT, WHICH TURNED BLUE—EARNING HIM THE NAME NEELKANTH. MAHASHIVRATRI MARKS THIS DIVINE ACT OF PROTECTION.

THE LINGA PURANA STATES THAT ON THIS NIGHT, LORD SHIVA APPEARED AS AN INFINITE PILLAR OF FIRE (JYOTIRLINGA) TO HUMBLE VISHNU AND BRAHMA, WHO FAILED TO FIND ITS LIMITS. THIS SYMBOLIZES SHIVA'S FORMLESS, BOUNDLESS NATURE AND MARKS THE WORSHIP OF THE SHIVLINGA AS ETERNAL COSMIC ENERGY.